

broadly software that alters the computer's behaviour for the benefit of the person who planted the software.

Spyware differs from viruses and worms in that it does not usually self-replicate. But like many viruses, spyware can exploit infected computers for commercial gain. Typical tactics include delivery of unsolicited pop-up ads, theft of personal information, monitoring of Web browsing activity, and routing of HTTP requests to advertising sites.

The term "adware" refers to any software which displays advertisements, whether or not it does so with the user's consent. Programs such as the Eudora mail client display advertisements as an alternative to registration fees. These classify as adware in the sense of "advertising-supported software," but not as spyware.

The most direct and common route by which Spyware gets on a computer is by the user installing it. Many Spyware programs deceive the user, either by piggybacking on a piece of desirable software, or by tricking the user to do something that installs the software without his realising it. A "Trojan horse", by definition, smuggles in something dangerous in the guise of something desirable. Some spyware programs spread in this manner. Spyware can also come bundled with shareware or other downloadable software, as well as music CDs. The user downloads a program—for instance, a music program—and installs it; the installer additionally installs the spyware. In some cases, spyware authors pay shareware authors to bundle spyware with their software.

Some of the more popular programs distributed with Spyware are BearShare, Download Accelerator Plus, ErrorGuard, FlashGet, and Kazaa Messenger Plus! (though this one lets the user choose during the installation whether to allow the adware to install or not).

Some of the popular anti-spyware software are Spybot Search & Destroy, and Lavasoft's Ad-Aware. These third-party software are easy to install, and like anti-virus software, need to be updated